

What Design Can't Do



Essays on Design and Disillusion

Silvio Lorusso

Set Margins' #26

Design is broken. Young and not-so-young designers are becoming increasingly aware of this. Many feel impotent: they were told they had the tools to make the world a better place, but instead the world takes its toll on them. Beyond a haze of hype and bold claims lies a barren land of self-doubt and impostor syndrome. Although these ‘feels’ might be the Millennial norm, design culture reinforces them. In conferences we learn that “with great power comes great responsibility” but, when it comes to real-life clients, all they ask is to “make the logo bigger.”

This book probes the disillusionment that permeates design. It tackles the deskilling effects provoked by digital semi-automation, the instances of ornamental politics fashioned to please the museum-educational complex, the nebulous promises of design schools. While reviving historical expressions of disenchantment, Silvio Lorusso examines present-day memes and social media rants. To depict this disheartening crisis, he crafts a new critical vocabulary for readers to build upon. What this exposé reveals is both worrying and refreshing: rather than producing a meaningful order, design might be about inhabiting chaos.



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Essays on Design and Disillusion
by Silvio Lorusso

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Set Margins'
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Praise for *What Design Can't Do*

“Are you a bit depressed about design? This book might help you understand why. It may also make you laugh. With a lightness of touch, Silvio Lorusso provides an unflinching but well-reasoned discussion as to how design has become so ‘bigged up’ and what this actually means for its practitioners. After reading this book, design will never look the same to you.”

– Guy Julier, author of *Economies of Design*

“What happens once design is a smokescreen and can no longer claim to be a blueprint for change? This is the question Silvio Lorusso puts on the table. How did form, no matter how cool and disruptive, become so futile and tired? Read this with caution: we can no longer design ourselves out of this painful realisation.”

– Geert Lovink, author of *Stuck on the Platform*

“The disillusion of design is the disillusion of the world. This book is an essential read, not only for specialists. Because design affects us all, and because understanding where design fails helps us understand where design succeeds.”

– Emanuele Quinz, author of *Strange Design*

“Italo-pessimist design critique at its best.”

– Clara Balaguer, cultural worker
and grey literature circulator



TABLE OF CONTENTS

	Prologue: Starter Pack	p. 14
1.	In the Middle	p. 32

PART I. EXPECTATIONS

2.	Everything Everyone All at Once: On Design Panism	p. 72
3.	A Complex Relationship: On Synthesis and Autonomy	p. 96
4.	Flipping the Table: On Power and Impotence	p. 130

PART II. REALITY

5.	Form Follows Format: On Semi-Automation and Cultural Professionalism	p. 168
6.	Kritikaoke: On Ornamental Politics and Identity as a Skill	p. 208
7.	The School as Real World: On Aspirations and Compromise	p. 244

	Epilogue: Ragequit	p. 290
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	Acknowledgements	p. 306
	Bibliography	p. 310
	Index of Names	p. 334

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To my friends

“The challenge of modernity is to live without illusions and without becoming disillusioned.”

– Antonio Gramsci, 1929–35¹

“Until today, the history of design has remained a history of defeats, suffered by the high-flying aspirations of the designers in their battle against utilization by *Das Kapital*.”

– Hans Magnus Enzensberger, 1972²

¹ Antonio Gramsci. *Letters from Prison*. New York: Columbia University Press, 1994.

² Hans Magnus Enzensberger. “Remarks Concerning the New York Universitas Project.” In *The Universitas Project: Solutions for a Post-Technological Society*, edited by Emilio Ambasz. New York: The Museum of Modern Art, 2006, p. 107.

Prologue:

Starter Pack

“[...] a fantastic paradox [concerns] modern industrial society and the way people live and act in it. It is the contradiction between the apparent omnipotence of humanity over its physical environment (the fact that technique is becoming more and more powerful, that physical conditions are increasingly controlled, that we are able to extract more and more energy from matter) and, on the other hand, the tremendous chaos and sense of impotence concerning the proper affairs of society, the human affairs, the way social systems work, etc.”

– Paul Cardan (Cornelius Castoriadis), 1965³

“Soon chaos will be our common denominator, we carry it within us and we will find it simultaneously in a thousand places, everywhere chaos will be the future of order, order already no longer makes sense, it is nothing more than an empty mechanism and we wear ourselves out to perpetuate it so that it can consign us to the irreparable.”

– Albert Caraco, 1982⁴

“In practice, of course a designer’s life is as muddled, informal, and accident-prone, as most people’s lives manage to be; not only behind the scenes, but sometimes in front of them.”

– Norman Potter, 1969⁵

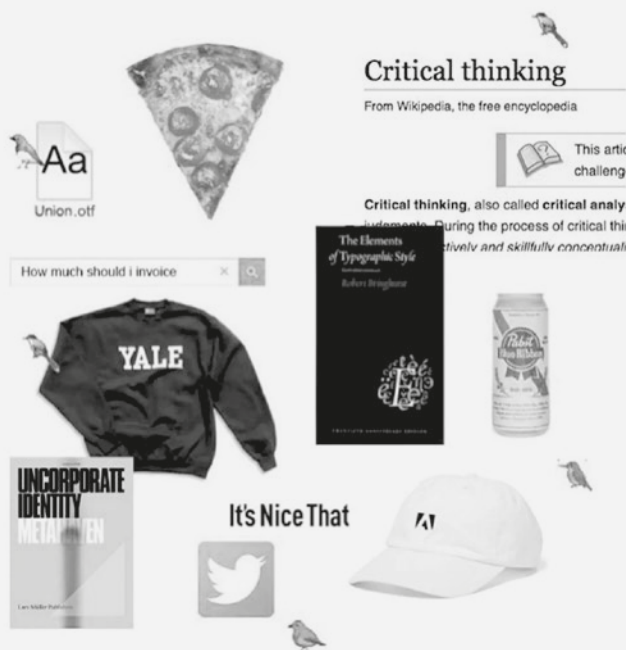
According to Victor Papanek, an early environmentalist, countercultural designer and outspoken critic of US consumerism, design is “the conscious and intuitive effort to impose meaningful order.” Hence, tidying up a desk, curating a party playlist, structuring the chapters of a book... all of these activities can be understood as a design endeavour. It is distressing, however, to realise that very few human activities escape this definition. If this is the case, what specific kind of order are designers meant to

3 Cornelius Castoriadis, *The Crisis of Modern Society*, Solidarity pamphlet No. 23, 1965. <https://libcom.org/article/crisis-modern-society-cornelius-castoriadis>.

4 Albert Caraco. *Breviario del caos*. Milano: Adelphi, 1998, p. 93.

5 Norman Potter. *What Is a Designer? Things, Places, Messages*. London: Hyphen Press, 2006, p. 19.

The "Basic Designer" Starter Pack.



A particularly niche graphic design starter pack.
Source unknown.

impose? And is it in any way more stable than the fragile, provisional order that we all attempt to carve, like a horde of industrious archivists in the Tower of Babel?

As every parent entering their kid's room knows, if design is about order, its precondition is not void, but chaos.⁶ The book you are reading locates itself within chaos. As such, it's a weird design book. It explores the disorder that can't be contained, the mess that overflows the dams of what we consider arranged and designed, including our mental models and subjectivities. Imposing a meaningful order begins with drawing the line that separates what is subject to the design effort from what it is not: the former is what designers generally call 'problem.' Design is a magic circle that produces an orderly inside and a chaotic outside. Designers safeguard and rework the circle's shifting border,⁷ and place ideas, things and people either within it or without it. But the line is porous: our attempts at ordering are inevitably artificial and their outcome necessarily unstable: entropy corrodes the negentropic islands that we call our projects. Order is always under siege. Chaos seeps in, corrupts the magic circle, erodes its contour. This collection of essays traces such erosion. Whereas what's inside design's magic circle can be defined, the chaos that surrounds it can only be described. Hence, *What Design Can't Do* is about describing more than prescribing.

Nowadays, chaos appears to be more powerful than order. Global-scale logistic systems seem as flawed as our tiny life projects. This is why today, more than ever, design

6 This is something that novelist Mary Shelley already pointed out in 1831: "Invention, it must be humbly admitted, does not consist in creating out of void, but out of chaos." The quote comes from a preface to her novel *Frankenstein; or The Modern Prometheus*. The plot seems to suggest that traces of chaos reside in the order, or even that order is nothing but provisionally patched chaos, like the body-corpse of the monster. See Maria Popova. "'Frankenstein' Author Mary Shelley on Creativity." *The Marginalian* (blog), June 25, 2018. <https://www.themarginalian.org/2018/06/25/mary-shelley-creativity-frankenstein-1831/>.

7 The general tendency is toward the border's extension: "And so we have been forced to expand the boundaries of the systems we deal with, trying to internalize those externalities." Horst W. J. Rittel and Melvin M. Webber. "Dilemmas in a General Theory of Planning." *Policy Sciences* 4, no. 2 (June 1, 1973): 155–69, p. 159.

is polarised. It feels either all-encompassing, infrastructural, planetary, big, baffling – or improvisational, ad-hoc, tiny, volatile. “Today’s design culture is an expression of our intense prototype lives – wails Geert Lovink – [p]recarity as an open and free lifestyle is getting stuck in a never-ending series of failures. Projects either fall through or never get finished. Life feels like an endless row of proposals.”⁸

Every problem is a wicked problem:⁹ its resolution is temporary, its paradigm ever-shifting, its focus evolving. How can one provide yet another abstract definition of the design process when the circumstances of a messy reality are so imposing? Design is left with only one option: staring chaos in the eyes, waiving the somewhat reassuring notion of ‘complexity.’¹⁰ For chaos is not complexity: complexity is a field where various forms of expertise compete; chaos is the repressed that returns when the experts fail. If, as James Bridle argues, “complexity is not a condition to be tamed, but a lesson to be learned,”¹¹ chaos is a grievance that has nothing to teach.

Things do not only appear intricate: they feel meaningless, alien, even to those of us who have devoted themselves to the cause of order. Designers are torn between having to believe, for professional and vocational reasons, in the modern promise of a harmonic, fluid orderliness and being caught in an absurd, glitchy reality. They are the ideal type of a hyper-modern subjectivity – disillusioned evangelists who are losing faith.

“Mess is the Law,” declares architect Jeremy Till: “It has taken me this long to work out that maybe architecture

8 Geert Lovink. “Precarious by Design.” In *Entreprenariat: Everyone Is an Entrepreneur, Nobody Is Safe*, by Silvio Lorusso. Eindhoven: Onomatopoe, 2019. pp. 10-12.

9 A wicked problem is a problem that can’t be unambiguously and definitively solved because its formulation is incomplete, shifting or even contradictory. The term was coined by design theorists Rittel and Webber, *op. cit.*

10 Hardly surprisingly many design papers and essays begin by paying an introductory tribute to complexity.

11 James Bridle. *New Dark Age: Technology and the End of the Future*. London: Verso, 2018, p. 138.

roses are red
violets are blue
PLEASE Don't Study PLEASE
Graphic Design

Critical Graphic Design (2015).
Source: <https://hahahardcore.tumblr.com/post/107967560350>.

is a mess; not an aesthetic mess but a much more complex social and institutional mess.”¹² Writing in the ’70s, architect Giancarlo De Carlo was more hopeful: “The mere sound of the word disorder generally provokes irrepressible neurosis, so it must be made clear that disorder does not mean the accumulation of a systematic dysfunction, but on the contrary the expression of a higher functionality capable of including and making manifest the complex interplay of all the variables involved in a spatial event [...] The salvation of the world – in all fields, from politics to aesthetics – is in disorder as the alternative of a constricting and overwhelming order that can no longer be shared.”¹³ In a similar vein, Henri Bergson argued that chaos is an order that we cannot see.¹⁴ What if, instead, we think of order as a chaos that we try to ignore? Theodor Adorno believed that the task of art was to bring chaos into order.¹⁵ Let’s at least bring it into focus.

Talking of her book *Composing a Life*, anthropologist Mary Catherine Bateson wrote that the project “started from a disgruntled reflection on my own life as a sort of desperate improvisation in which I was constantly trying to make something coherent from conflicting elements to fit rapidly changing settings.”¹⁶ Here, I engage with a similar urgency, which I believe to be commonly felt. To do so, I explore the mechanisms that are put forward to maintain the illusion of order and the confidence in those who can bring it about. The goal is to shed light on the sense of disillusionment deriving from the distance between orderly expectations and a chaotic reality. A focus on this distance,

12 Jeremy Till. *Architecture Depends*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2013, p. XII.

13 Giancarlo De Carlo. *La piramide rovesciata: architettura oltre il ’68*. Macerata: Quodlibet, 2018, pp. 112-4.

14 Quoted in Tomás Maldonado. *La speranza progettuale: ambiente e società*. Torino: Einaudi, 1997, p. 112.

15 Theodor W. Adorno. *Minima Moralia: Reflections from Damaged Life*. London: Verso, 1978, p. 222.

16 Quoted in Penelope Green. “Mary Catherine Bateson Dies at 81; Anthropologist on Lives of Women.” *The New York Times*, January 14, 2021. <https://www.nytimes.com/2021/01/14/books/mary-catherine-bateson-dead.html>.

which might seem alien to the mission of design, is in fact at its core. After all, identifying a problem means nothing other than “knowing what distinguishes an observed condition from a desired condition.”¹⁷ The point is not to ‘fix’ disillusionment, but to understand its origin and the way it affects beliefs and behaviour. To do so, we must place ourselves *in the middle*, looking at how designers have to negotiate between management and execution, technics and humanities, autonomy and dependence, power and subjugation, bureaucracy and innovation, things and self.

* * *

What does the chaos surrounding the magic circle of design look like? Being unable to generalise, as chaos is always unique, I can only describe my own: a draconian series of InDesign paragraph styles, a lost Indexhibit site, a logo commissioned on Fiverr for a laugh, an absent-minded visit to the Dutch Design Week, a 404 error on a wrong jQuery URL in a static webpage, a bunch of risoprint zines, a student’s expiring visa, a weak eduroam WiFi access point, a crowdfunded exhibition, a poster about the Anthropocene depicting mushrooms and bacteria, a Linmon-Lerberg IKEA desk travelling from one rented room to another, an unpaid internship report, a video essay featuring a North-American female voice-over, an Instagram ad followed by a @dank.lloyd.wright meme, some dusty mammoth Taschen volumes left at my dad’s place, variable fonts, walking tote bags, people dressed like posters, hand-made protest signs, post-its, a dub DJ-set, Cinema 4D free assets, a Twitter hot take on the new CIA brand, a bachelor thesis on transhumanism, an urgent email from an obnoxious client, an alignment error on a 1200 print-run, two herniated discs, a MacBook Pro with Touch Bar, a pair of Lidl flip-flops, an expired

¹⁷ Rittel and Webber, *op. cit.*, p. 159.

Adobe Creative Cloud subscription, the daily advice of Stefan Sagmeister, a coffee-stained funding application, the e-flux spinner pattern, a witty rip-off of the MAGA hat, 10-page portfolios (10mb max), a Unity-based exploratory “videogame,” a Marcel Breuer tubular chair (tried once in a corporate office), this very Markdown file edited in dark mode.

Someone who is familiar with design in the Global North (and probably elsewhere too) might have some of these items in their personal design starter pack. “Starter pack” is the name of a meme in which the defining features of a certain profession, subculture or fandom are displayed against a white background.¹⁸ They can be items, tools, books or even habits. Often, clothes and accessories are included, showing that much of our professional identity inevitably conforms to a certain stereotype and signals it. Many different starter packs for the designer category exist: “the graphic design student” starter pack, the “pretentious designer” one, the “pissing off a graphic designer” version... Their implicit message being that there is no fundamental difference between tools, devices, literature or accessories. Everything is an appendix of identity, something that contributes to a sense of belonging, and in some lucky cases, to the accumulation of prestige. The starter pack meme highlights something else as well, namely that identity formation combines consumption with professional production. Or even that profession is, at least in part, a form of consumption.¹⁹ A chaotic assemblage of designerly stuff floating on a white canvas is supposed to alchemically generate personal character and personalised meaning. Mieke Gerritzen and Geert Lovink speak of “an aesthetic ambiance around your personality, filled with seductive ideas, things and experiences.”²⁰ But this form of

¹⁸ See <https://knowyourmeme.com/memes/starter-packs>.

¹⁹ I expand on this point in chapter 5.

²⁰ Mieke Gerritzen and Geert Lovink. *Made in China, Designed in California, Criticised in Europe: Design Manifesto*. Amsterdam: BIS Publishers, 2020.

High school friend: "My husband just got a promotion, I'm pregnant and we just bought our first house.

Me:



aesthetic identification is fragile. Another recent memetic formula reads: “designer is not a personality.” There is a growing feeling that both profession and consumption are insufficient means to build a solid, stable identity.

If we look specifically at graphic design, a dense, complex starter pack is the one built over three years in the Tumblr blog Critical Graphic Design.²¹ There, one can scroll through a plethora of obscure inside jokes (some already outdated as the blog shut down in 2015), an obsession with avantgarde designers who are also cultural producers, especially from the Netherlands, the UK and the US (such as Experimental Jetset, Zak Keys, Michael Bierut), the parody of “criticality” as an attitude to display, some modified screenshots of the Photoshop interface, non-existing hyperstitional theory books.²² Also noticeable is the mechanism of self-canonisation typical of small scenes, a fixation on ivy-league design schools such Yale (but pictures of Yale forklifts are shown instead), an ironic indulgence in amateur design, a sensibility towards precarity and the hardships of the job market, a few rants on the hypocrisy of political design, an acute awareness of consumerism and profession as two intersecting domains (“Everything is stuff,” a book by Metahaven along with a Nike pair of sneakers or a Guy Fawkes mask). Finally, some traces of disillusion (“roses are red violets are blue please please don’t study graphic design”).

Design critic Francisco Laranjo lamented the lack of coherence of the blog, but it was exactly its schizophrenic

Originally, the subtitle of the book was “Amsterdam Design Manifesto”, an apt choice that situates the specific design chaos the authors describe. Having lived in the Netherlands for several years, I get their perspective. This is why their books will appear frequently in the following pages. But, whereas Gerritzen and Lovink focus mainly on the contemporary state of design, I concentrate on the state of *designers*, who are the first to be redesigned by it.

²¹ <https://criticalgraphicdesign.tumblr.com>.

²² Hyperstition is a term coined by writer and philosopher Nick Land. A portmanteau of the words “hyper” and “superstition,” it suggests that ideas can be pushed into the cultural arena where they reinforce themselves, functioning as memetic self-fulfilling prophecies. See Delphi Carstens. “Hyperstition.” *orphan Drift Archive* (blog), 2010. <https://www.orphandrifarchive.com/articles/hyperstition/>.

polyvocality that gave Critical Graphic Design its edge.²³ Critique is no less messy than affirmation. Furthermore, what the anonymous group behind the blog was suggesting, already more than eight years ago, is that next to the visible lifestyle and professional items of design personality, there is a hidden starter pack,²⁴ one made of silent, sometimes unconscious factors: nightmarish bureaucratic procedures, financial troubles, rich families, gender biases, shitty clients, unpaid internships, dynamics of micro or macro-celebrity, generous funding or lack thereof, networks of friends, circles of gossip and so on. These threaten or sustain the project of doing projects: the professional life project of becoming a cultivated designer, a cultural professional, and more crucially, of remaining one.

A more recent meme could have easily been featured on Critical Graphic Design. Here, someone brags about her achievements: “My husband got a promotion, I’m pregnant and we just bought our first house.” Unlike the accomplished high-school friend, the meme protagonist is busy joining vector points in Adobe Illustrator, an infamously tedious process that disgracefully hasn’t been automated yet. There is much to unpack in this low-resolution image. First, a traditional idea of success and the good life (only the SUV is missing). Then, a vivid expression of personal disorientation and self-doubt. The meme also speaks of the trivialisation of skills and the drabness of the design profession, which is, for the most part, littered with repetitive tasks.

Finally, it seems to suggest that the exchange is happening between two women. This is no coincidence. For women it is structurally more difficult to get to the top as a designer and reach a position that is either authorial or

23 Francisco Laranjo. “Critical Graphic Design: Critical of What?” *Design Observer*, April 16, 2014. <http://designobserver.com/feature/critical-graphic-design-critical-of-what/38416>.

24 The hidden starter pack refers to the notion of hidden curriculum theorised by, among others, John Dewey, Ivan Illich and Paulo Freire. See https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hidden_curriculum.

PROLOGUE



GRMMXI (2014).

Source: <https://grmmxi.fi/post/75583597164>.

authoritative.²⁵ Women are more likely to be stuck with the tiny, menial aspects of the job. After all, one tactic to protect oneself from the chaos of life is to narrow one's project down, to make it as small as the distance between two zoomed-in vector points. The 'tiny' design project, with its controllable Bézier curves, can act as shelter from the life project, which often seems chaotic and meaningless – quite the opposite of the baby-boomer family image painted by the meme's accomplished friend.

* * *

Italian cultural critic Tommaso Labranca once listed two opposite artificial hells of art and design practitioners. On the one hand, the aseptic horror of the white cube; on the other hand, “the nightmare of chaos experienced in the always temporary and shaky dwellings of the artistic underworld.”²⁶ In 2018, Airbnb launched a series of design talks entitled *When Chaos Is Your Creative Director*.²⁷ The choice of topic makes a lot of sense for a company which deals with people dressing up their room and apartments, often small and Escheresque, into pleasant, generic habitats for tourists and business visitors alike.²⁸ The people at Airbnb explain: “[...] while the fog of chaos leaves some of us frozen, there are rare talents who can see clearly enough to activate and create.” That's the hope: to be one of the lucky few who not only builds order, but protects it from seeping chaos.

They insist: “Because chaos is inevitable. Because we live in a world of political unrest, health crises, and

25 Ruber Pater reports that while most graphic design students are women, the designers who run studios are predominantly male. *Caps Lock: How Capitalism Took Hold of Graphic Design, and How to Escape from It*. Amsterdam: Valiz, 2021, p. 294.

26 Tommaso Labranca. *Vraghinaroda: Sopravvivendo a hipster situazionisti, santexuperine scalze e mistificatori deleuziani*. Milano: 20090, 2019, p. 84.

27 <https://airbnb.design/designed-chaos/> and <https://airbnb.design/seasontwo/>.

28 Journalist Kyle Chayka dubbed this aesthetic style “airspace.” See “How Silicon Valley Helps Spread the Same Sterile Aesthetic Across the World.” *The Verge*, August 3, 2016. <https://www.theverge.com/2016/8/3/12325104/airbnb-aesthetic-global-minimalism-startup-gentrification>.

questionable ethical tech (*sic*), and design plays a critical role in addressing these global challenges.” Even a behemoth company can’t avoid admitting the inevitability of chaos, this blob-like material which is at the same time sublimely large and mundanely tiny, an agent whose indifference resists most organising efforts. Chaos precedes design and operates inside it: it is the manifestation of the Real beyond the designerly illusion of a stable and durable order. Given the chaotic qualities of design, one could appreciate the improvisational, almost absurdist illustration of designing provided by Enzo Mari, a legendary Italian designer who, growing up in the rubble of World War II, was first a vocal design utopianist, then a disillusioned realist, and finally a sort of Great Hater of the design world:

We all design, every day, when we are forced to make our own decisions, even the seemingly trivial ones. For example, having to cook and finding in the fridge only a cup of yogurt and two onions.²⁹

One way to look at design is by the capacity of its action, that is, the order it imposes. But design is also, more simply and fundamentally, yogurt and onions – what we are left with, the mess we’re in.

29 Enzo Mari. *25 modi per piantare un chiodo: Sessant’anni di idee e progetti per difendere un sogno*. Milano: Mondadori, 2011, p. 5.



PROLOGUE



Found image. Source unknown.

Silvio Lorusso is a writer, artist and designer based in Lisbon, Portugal. In 2018, he published his first book entitled *Entreprecariat: Everyone is an Entrepreneur. Nobody Is Safe*. He is an assistant professor and co-director of the Center for Other Worlds at the Lusófona University in Lisbon and a tutor at the Information Design Department of the Design Academy Eindhoven. Lorusso holds a Ph.D. in Design Sciences from the Iuav University of Venice. Paraphrasing the Italian architect Franco Raggi, he writes and talks about design, though actually doing very little of it, and believing in it less and less.

